Calvert Watkins at UCLA

BRENT VINE
University of California, Los Angeles

There have already been many occasions to offer tributes to Calvert Watkins or to reminisce about him; and while much has been said, there is much more that could be said. But my aim here is very modest: I simply want to recall some things about Calvert Watkins during his time as Professor of Classics and Indo-European Studies at UCLA.[1]

I stand before you as a former student of Calvert Watkins, and also, I'd like to think, a friend. But about ten years ago, toward the end of a seven-year tour of duty as Head of the UCLA Program in Indo-European Studies, I found myself in the incredible position (as it seemed to me) of being, in effect, Calvert Watkins' future employer. This, of course, struck me as preposterous, as pleasing as it was to be partly responsible for bringing Cal to UCLA, and for making sure that he had an official UCLA appointment. And for anyone familiar with the UCLA bureaucracy, it will come as no surprise that in order for Calvert Watkins to be hired by UCLA at the rank of Professor, he had to undergo a full-scale evaluation—and because of that, I had to solicit letters of support from about a dozen senior Indo-Europeanists the world over. I must say that I really enjoyed reading those letters: nearly every one of them protested that the idea of anyone's writing a letter of recommendation for a figure like Calvert Watkins was patently absurd.

Cal's appointment as Professor-in-Residence of Classics and Indo-European Studies was eventually approved, and both departments were the richer for it. Cal made it clear that he was, after all, retired; but in fact, he was an active member of both departments: teaching occasional courses, participating in dissertation committees, attending lectures, even auditing graduate seminars—particularly in Classics, where my Classics colleagues, though perhaps a little intimidated at first, soon came to value his presence in their classes. A personal high point for me came when I audited Cal's graduate seminar on "Greek Epigraphic Verse," which he taught in the Spring Quarter of 2005. What I enjoyed wasn't so much the odd situation of finding myself, as if in a time machine, transported back to Cal's classroom (minus the Gauloise cigarettes)—because frankly, I was a little nervous that I'd get called on! Rather, it was the pleasure of seeing yet another generation of students (namely, my own graduate students in Classics and Indo-

1 This is a lightly revised version of remarks presented at the beginning of the 25th Annual UCLA Indo-European Conference (25 October 2013).

European Studies) experience and benefit from Cal's teaching, from his immense store of knowledge, and generally from his humanity. And there were other interactions worth remembering, not least of all Cal's regular participation, up until this year, in the review of the abstracts for this very conference; and also the fact that one of his last papers was delivered at this conference last year, now published in the proceedings volume for that conference.[2]

There are two other occasions that stick in my mind, both from a time shortly before his death. On March 1st of this year, when Cal was recovering from various ailments and still in some discomfort, he showed up, to my surprise and delight, at a Classics Department reception, held at the end of our visiting period for the graduate student candidates being recruited for admission to the department. Cal sat down at a table, and with a plate of hors d'oeuvres and a glass of wine within reach (which we refilled from time to time), he graciously held court and chatted amiably with one and all: with faculty and staff colleagues, and with both current and prospective graduate students. And then, about two and a half weeks later, I was delighted to see Cal at a meeting of our "Anatolian Club," which took place at the home of Jaan Puhvel, in the company of other Indo-European colleagues. Cal passed away the following morning. Somehow, I find it comforting that I was able to spend part of his last night with him, and to see him engaging in many of the things that gave him (and us) so much pleasure: talking about Hittite and Indo-European, telling choice anecdotes (with punchlines in a variety of perfectly-accented languages), and enjoying good food and drink in the company of colleagues and friends.

2 "Aspects of the 'Expressive Dimension' in Indo-European: Toward a Comparative Grammar of Speech Registers," in Stephanie W. Jamison, H. Craig Melchert, and Brent Vine (eds.), *Proceedings of the 24th Annual UCLA Indo-European Conference* (Bremen: Hempen, 2013), 243–53.